



What you need to know - Heart transplant

This handout tells you what you need to know about a heart transplant to live better and avoid serious problems.



What is it?

- A heart transplant is a surgery to take out the diseased heart and replace it with a healthy heart.
- You must take medicines for the rest of your life.
 - These medicines help keep your body from rejecting the heart transplant.
 - Your body may reject the heart transplant any time if you stop taking your medicines.



What types of care may I need?

- Goals for care
 - Feel better and stay active
 - Treat and prevent problems
 - Better quality of life
- Equipment or supplies
 - Compression stockings
 - Weight scale
 - Wound care supplies
- Medicines
 - Erythropoiesis-stimulating agents (ESAs) help the body make more red blood cells.

- Immunosuppressives reduce the body's immune system response.
- Steroids reduce swelling and treat bad flare ups.
- Home healthcare
- Community resources



What follow-up care do I need?

- Surgeon or transplant team visits
- Tests, like blood, urine, EKG (electrocardiogram), ultrasound, or x-rays
- Heart biopsies
- Cancer screenings, like cervix, breast, colon, prostate, or skin
- Bone density tests for osteoporosis
- Vaccinations that are not made from live viruses
- Annual eye exams
- Dental care



What can I do?

- Managing a heart transplant includes following a daily care plan. See the **Daily care for your condition - Organ transplant** handout.
- Make and keep all doctor visits.
- Take your medicine as your doctor told you.
- Stay away from crowds and people who are sick with colds or flu.
- Protect your skin when you go outside. Cover your skin with clothes or wear sunscreen that is SPF30 or higher.
- Keep your weight at a healthy number.
- Take care of other health problems that you have.
- Make lifestyle changes, like stop smoking, eat healthy foods, and be active.

- Learn to manage stress. Keep in touch with family and friends. Ask for help if you need it.
- Know when to call for help.
 - Get emergency help right away if you think you are having a heart attack or stroke.
 - Contact your transplant doctor right away if you show signs of rejection.
 - See the **When to get help - Organ transplant** handout.



Where can I learn more?

- Review some Internet resources.
 - American Heart Association. Go to: www.heart.org
 - National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute. National Institutes of Health. Go to: www.nhlbi.nih.gov
 - Smokefree.gov. National Institutes of Health. Go to: www.smokefree.gov
- Talk to your doctor about what you learn.

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

